

Learn How to Write Apps for the Firefox OS

Recently, Mozilla released its first line of phones, which run the Firefox OS. In case you haven't heard about it, the Firefox OS is a standalone Web-centric operating system in which the development platform is the HTML5 stack. This article focuses on showing readers how to get started with app development for the Firefox OS.



The aim of the Firefox project is to bring about full device integration, in a manner that allows Web developers to have the same capabilities as OS-specific technologies. What this means is that developers could, with minimal tweaks to existing Web apps, port the same to the Firefox OS, thus saving valuable time and minimising development effort. The Firefox OS is quite interesting in that you challenge all preconceived notions of native apps, with simple HTML, CSS and JavaScript.

Developing your first application for Firefox OS

There are fundamentally two kinds of applications that can be installed on the Firefox OS.

- **Hosted apps:** These apps are websites hosted on a server, and the app simply accesses the server for various resources like images and other files needed for the app to function. As you can imagine, the scope of such apps is limited by the functionality provided by the Web API.
- **Packaged apps:** These are still HTML5 apps, but they are downloaded and installed locally, instead of being centrally hosted. These apps usually function without

any network access. In this tutorial, we will focus on this type of app, but resources on the former can easily be found online.

Before we get started, make sure you have the latest stable release of the Firefox Web browser installed. You will now need to set up the Firefox OS simulator add-on (<https://addons.mozilla.org/en-US/firefox/addon/firefox-os-simulator/>). This is a free Mozilla add-on that will let you simulate the Firefox OS in your Web browser. If you already have a Firefox device, you can use this tool to push your app to the device from the simulator (it detects connected devices). You can find it in the Web developer menu in Firefox, under 'Firefox OS Simulator'. See Figure 1 for a screen shot of the simulator dashboard.

Now, in your documents, you can create a folder (in this tutorial we have named it *myapp*). This is going to be the directory in which your Firefox OS app will reside. In this tutorial, we will create the app from scratch, but there are various tools that will create the basic structure for the Firefox OS app (you